Finance Jobs Decoded: Accounting, Tax, Audit & FP&A

What Employers Actually Want — Decoded from Real 2026 Job Postings (India-first)

Role by role: responsibilities, skills, tools, certifications, ATS keywords, salary bands & how to break in

Contents

How to Read a Finance Job Description (and This Book)

Most commerce and MBA-Finance graduates in India learn a curriculum, then walk into a job market that speaks a different language. Your college taught you the *why* of accounting, taxation and finance. A job description (JD) tells you the *what* — the specific software, the specific compliance forms, the specific monthly rituals a company will pay you to perform from day one. This book exists to close that gap. It takes real finance job postings pulled from Indeed India in mid-2026 and decodes them, one role at a time, so you know exactly what each job wants and how to get it.

The education-to-industry gap

A B.Com graduate can define "bank reconciliation" in an exam. A JD asks whether you can actually reconcile a live bank statement in Tally against a messy day-book with 200 entries and explain the differences to an auditor. An MBA can build a DCF in a case study; an equity research JD wants you to build a working three-statement model, run channel checks on a real company, and write a note an institutional investor will act on. The gap is not intelligence — it's *specificity and tooling*. Employers assume you know the theory; they are hiring for the execution. The moment you start reading JDs as instruction manuals rather than wish-lists, your preparation becomes ten times more efficient, because you stop studying everything and start building the exact three or four things a role actually rewards.

The anatomy of a finance JD

Almost every finance posting has the same skeleton. Learn to X-ray it:

- **Role summary** — one or two lines placing the job in the org (e.g. "support month-end close within the R2R team"). This tells you where you sit and who you report to.
- **Responsibilities / "What you'll do"** — the real work. This is the single most important section. Read it as your future daily to-do list, not marketing copy.
- **Must-have qualifications** — non-negotiable filters: a degree, a minimum number of years, sometimes a specific qualification (CA, CFA, ACAMS). If a posting says "CA-qualified 1–3 yrs," a fresher B.Com simply will not clear the screen, however talented.
- **Nice-to-have / "preferred"** — the differentiators. "MBA/CA/CMA a plus," "Power BI desirable," "ACAMS an advantage." You don't need all of these, but each one you have moves you up the pile.
- **Tools** — the named software (Tally, SAP, Oracle, Zoho, Bloomberg, Power BI, Anaplan). These are literal keywords; more on that below.

Must-have vs nice-to-have is the whole game. Spend your energy clearing every must-have for the role you actually want, then collect nice-to-haves to stand out. Applying to a job where you miss a must-have (the certification, the years, the mandatory tool) is usually wasted effort.

How ATS parses your keywords

Large and mid-size employers run your resume through an Applicant Tracking System (ATS) before a human ever sees it. The ATS does not understand nuance — it matches strings. If the JD says "three-way match" and your resume says "invoice verification," the machine may not connect them. So the rule is blunt: **mirror the**

JD's exact vocabulary. If the posting says "GST filings," "TDS deductions," "bank reconciliation," "R2R," "variance analysis," or "Power BI," those literal phrases should appear on your resume — truthfully, tied to something you've actually done. Every role chapter in this book ends with an **ATS keywords to mirror** section for exactly this reason: it hands you the terms to plant.

The map of core / back-office finance roles

This book covers the backbone of Indian finance employment — the roles that exist in every company, from a Hyderabad SME to a Bangalore Global Capability Centre (GCC). They connect as a natural progression of how money is recorded, checked, reported and planned:

Accounts → Tax → Audit → Controllership → FP&A

- **Accounts** (Accountant, AP, R2R/GL) — record every transaction correctly. This is where most commerce grads enter.
- **Tax** (Tax Analyst, GST/TDS work) — ensure what's recorded complies with income-tax and GST law.
- **Audit & Controllership** — verify the books are true and own the monthly/annual close under Indian GAAP.
- **FP&A** — stop looking backwards and start looking forward: budgets, forecasts, variance vs plan, and the numbers that guide the business.

Alongside this spine sit the specialist tracks the market also hires heavily for — payroll, treasury, credit risk, KYC/AML and compliance, and the front-office roles (investment banking, equity research, private equity). Each gets its own decoded chapter.

How to use each chapter

Every role chapter follows the same ten-part structure so you can compare roles side by side: a **Snapshot** (what the role is and its seniority ladder), **What you'll actually do**, **Must-have skills**, **Tools & software**, **Qualifications & certifications**, **Experience & typical titles**, **ATS keywords to mirror**, an indicative **Salary in India** table, **Who's hiring**, and **How to break in / stand out**. Read the Snapshot to decide if a role fits you, then jump to *How to break in* for the concrete next step and the portfolio project that will separate you from other applicants.

An honest note on entry difficulty and pay

Be clear-eyed: the entry rungs of Indian finance are competitive and, at the bottom, modestly paid. An SME Accountant role in Hyderabad may pay Rs 20,000–35,000 a month — genuinely low for the volume of work — but it is the most reliable foot-in-the-door for a B.Com graduate and builds the Tally-plus-compliance base everything else stands on. GCC roles (AP, R2R, FP&A) pay better and offer clearer ladders but demand process discipline and often night or shifted hours. The high-paying front-office roles (IB, equity research, credit risk) are genuinely hard to enter, want an MBA or CA plus strong modelling, and run long hours. There is no shortcut, but there is a map — and the difference between a frustrated job-seeker and a hired one is usually not talent, but knowing precisely what each role wants and showing up already able to do it. That is what the rest of this book gives you.

Accountant / Accounts Executive

Snapshot

The Accountant / Accounts Executive is the entry workhorse of Indian finance — the person who actually records the business's money, day in and day out. In an SME or mid-market firm (think a Hyderabad trading company, a manufacturing unit, a services outfit like Valtree Global), this role owns the books at the ground level: posting vouchers in Tally, chasing receivables, paying vendors, reconciling the bank, and filing GST and TDS on time. It sits at the base of the org, usually reporting to a Senior Accountant, Accounts Manager, or directly to the proprietor/finance head in a small firm. The ladder from here is clear and well-trodden: **Accounts Executive → Senior Accounts Executive → Assistant Accounts Manager → Accounts Manager**. For the vast majority of B.Com graduates in India, this is where a finance career begins — and it is the single best place to build the practical, compliance-heavy foundation every later role assumes you have.

What you'll actually do

The work is high-volume, hands-on, and deadline-driven around statutory dates (GST returns, TDS payments, month-end). Synthesised from real SME postings, a typical day/week includes:

- Recording day-to-day transactions in Tally ERP / TallyPrime — sales and purchase vouchers, journals, receipts, payments, contra entries — and maintaining the day-book and ledgers.
- **Accounts Payable (AP):** booking vendor bills, matching them to purchase orders, and scheduling payments.
- **Accounts Receivable (AR):** raising customer invoices, tracking outstanding dues, and following up on collections.
- Performing **bank reconciliation** — matching book balances to bank statements and resolving differences.
- Handling **GST** — computing liability, reconciling input tax credit, and filing returns (GSTR-1, GSTR-3B).
- Deducting and depositing **TDS**, and supporting other statutory compliance.
- Assisting in the preparation of monthly and annual financial statements.
- Supporting statutory and internal **audits** — pulling ledgers, vouchers, and schedules the auditors ask for.
- Using MS Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables) for reconciliations, MIS, and data clean-up.

> Real posting (Valtree Global): "Manage day-to-day accounting entries in Tally, handle AP/AR, perform bank reconciliations, and assist with GST filings and TDS deductions."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: working knowledge of Tally ERP / TallyPrime; solid grasp of double-entry bookkeeping; practical GST and TDS computation and filing; bank and ledger reconciliation; Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables, basic formulas); ability to assist in preparing financial statements. **Soft skills:** accuracy and attention to detail (a wrong voucher ripples into the audit), discipline around statutory deadlines, organisation under high transaction volume, and clear communication with vendors, customers, and auditors.

Tools & software

- **Tally ERP 9 / TallyPrime** — the non-negotiable core in Indian SMEs.
- **MS Excel** — VLOOKUP, PivotTables, reconciliations, MIS.
- **GST portal** and **TRACES / income-tax portal** for filings.
- In slightly larger or newer firms you may also see **Zoho Books**, **Busy**, or **QuickBooks**.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com is the standard entry qualification; M.Com is a plus.
- **CA-Inter / CMA-Inter (dropouts or pursuing):** genuinely welcomed and often preferred — postings frequently say "CA/CMA-inter welcome." Even partial progress signals stronger fundamentals.
- **Certifications that help here:** a practical **Tally certification** and a hands-on **GST practitioner / GST-filing course** are the most cost-effective credentials for this specific role. Global certs like CFA/FMVA add little at this rung — save them for later analytical roles.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry	0–2 yrs	Accounts Executive, Junior Accountant, Accounts Assistant
Mid	2–4 yrs	Accountant, Senior Accounts Executive
Senior	5+ yrs	Senior Accountant, Assistant Accounts Manager

Most SME postings ask for **2–3 years**, but freshers are regularly hired if they know Tally and GST basics.

ATS keywords to mirror

Tally ERP, TallyPrime, accounts payable, accounts receivable, bank reconciliation, GST filing, GSTR-1, GSTR-3B, TDS deduction, statutory compliance, journal entries, vouchers, day-book, ledger, financial statements, audit support, MS Excel, VLOOKUP, PivotTables, input tax credit

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0–2 yrs)	2.0 – 4.0
2–4 yrs	3.5 – 6.0
5–8 yrs	5.0 – 9.0

SME postings often quote **Rs 20,000–35,000/month** (roughly Rs 2.4–4.2 LPA). Figures vary by city, firm size, and sector, and are approximate.

Who's hiring

Small and mid-market businesses across every sector — trading companies, manufacturers, distributors, service firms, CA firms, and startups. Real examples of this type on Indeed include SME employers such as **Valtree Global** (Hyderabad) and countless similar firms in Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, Coimbatore, and every Tier-1 and Tier-2 city. CA firms also hire heavily at this level for audit and compliance support.

How to break in / stand out

For a commerce graduate, this is the most accessible entry point in finance — but "accessible" means crowded, so you must show you can do the job on day one:

1. **Master TallyPrime end-to-end.** Don't just list it — be able to demonstrate a company set up in Tally with sample vouchers, a bank recon, and a GST return generated from it.
2. **Learn GST and TDS filing practically.** Do a short, hands-on GST course and actually file (or shadow-file) a GSTR-3B. Being able to say "I have filed GST returns" beats "I studied GST."
3. **Build a mini portfolio:** a one-page Excel showing a bank reconciliation you built, a debtors-ageing PivotTable, and a screenshot of a Tally trial balance you produced. Bring it to the interview.
4. **Consider CA-Inter or CMA-Inter** even if you don't complete the full qualification — clearing a group signals stronger fundamentals and often unlocks a better starting salary.

The single biggest differentiator: being genuinely fluent in Tally *plus* current GST/TDS compliance, so a small business owner can hand you the books and walk away. Most fresh graduates know the theory; very few can independently run a monthly compliance cycle. Be the one who can, and you'll never struggle to get this job — or to climb out of it.

Senior Accountant / Accounts Manager

Snapshot

The Senior Accountant / Accounts Manager is the person who *owns the books* — the step up from recording transactions to being accountable for their accuracy, completeness, and finalisation. Where the Accounts Executive posts vouchers, the Senior Accountant reviews them, closes the month, signs off on GST and TDS returns, coordinates the statutory audit, and puts the MIS in front of the owner or CFO. In an SME or mid-market firm this is often the senior-most finance role below the proprietor; in a larger company it sits under a Financial Controller or Finance Manager. It is a supervisory and finalisation role: you manage one or more junior accountants, catch their errors before the auditor does, and are the single point of accountability for the numbers. The ladder: **Senior Accountant → Assistant Accounts Manager → Accounts Manager → Finance Manager / Controller.** Reaching this rung typically means CA-Inter / CMA-Inter plus experience, or roughly five-plus years of hands-on accounting.

What you'll actually do

Synthesised from real controllership-leaning postings (Plum-type and SME manager roles), the work shifts from *doing* to *owning and reviewing*:

- Own the **month-end, quarter-end, and year-end close** — ensure all entries are booked, accrued, and reconciled to a timeline.
- Prepare and finalise **financial statements** under Indian GAAP (P&L, balance sheet, cash flow).
- Review and **sign off on GST and TDS returns** prepared by juniors; own reconciliations (GSTR-2B vs books, TDS vs 26AS).
- Supervise and review the work of junior accountants — vouchers, ledgers, and reconciliations.
- Maintain **internal financial controls** and ensure books are audit-ready.
- **Coordinate statutory, tax, and internal audits** — be the primary point of contact for auditors, provide schedules, and resolve queries.
- Perform three-way and bank reconciliations and review balance-sheet schedules with commentary.
- Prepare **MIS and management reports** for the owner/CFO — monthly numbers, variances, and cash position.
- Support treasury and cash-flow forecasting where required.

> Real posting (Plum): "Manage month/quarter/annual close, prepare financial statements under Indian GAAP, maintain internal financial controls, and assist statutory, tax, and internal audits."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: full-cycle accounting and finalisation; strong Indian GAAP knowledge; month-end close discipline; GST and TDS return preparation *and review*; balance-sheet reconciliations with commentary; internal controls; audit coordination; advanced Excel. **Soft skills:** ownership and accountability (the buck stops with you), review rigour and error-spotting, ability to manage and mentor juniors, and the communication skills to present numbers to a non-finance owner and defend them to an auditor.

Tools & software

- **Tally ERP / TallyPrime** and/or **Zoho Books** — core in Indian SMEs and mid-market.
- **Advanced Excel** — reconciliations, schedules, MIS dashboards.
- **GST portal**, **TRACES / income-tax portal** for filings and reconciliations.
- Larger firms may run **SAP**, **Oracle**, or **NetSuite** — familiarity is a plus as you move up.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com.
- **CA-Inter or CMA-Inter** is the sweet-spot qualification for this rung and is often explicitly preferred; a fully qualified **CA** or **CMA** commands the Accounts Manager title and a higher band, especially where Indian GAAP finalisation and audit coordination are central.
- **Certifications that help here:** advanced GST/tax certifications and an Indian GAAP / Ind AS course. FMVA or CFA are not required here but signal analytical depth if you plan to pivot toward FP&A later.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry to this rung	4–6 yrs (or CA/CMA-Inter + 1–3 yrs)	Senior Accountant, Accounts Team Lead
Mid	6–9 yrs	Assistant Accounts Manager, Deputy Manager – Accounts
Senior	9+ yrs	Accounts Manager, Finance Manager

CA-qualified candidates can reach the manager title in **1–3 years** post-qualification; the non-qualified route typically takes **5+ years** of strong hands-on experience.

ATS keywords to mirror

month-end close, financial statements, Indian GAAP, internal financial controls, statutory audit, GST returns, TDS, balance sheet reconciliation, general ledger review, finalisation of accounts, MIS reporting, audit coordination, variance analysis, Ind AS, team supervision, cash flow, TallyPrime, Zoho

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher to this rung (CA/CMA-Inter, ~2 yrs)	5.0 – 8.0
2–4 yrs in role	7.0 – 12.0
5–8 yrs in role	10.0 – 18.0

A fully qualified CA at Accounts Manager level in a mid-market firm can sit at the upper end. Figures vary widely by city, firm size, and sector, and are approximate.

Who's hiring

Mid-market and growing companies across manufacturing, services, retail, and tech; startups scaling past their first finance hire (e.g. Plum-type insurtech/SaaS firms hiring controllership talent in Bangalore); CA firms building their accounting/outsourcing practices; and any SME whose owner wants to step back from day-to-day finance. Hubs include Bangalore, Hyderabad, Mumbai, Pune, and Chennai.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Clear CA-Inter or CMA-Inter** — this is the fastest, most credible route to the title and pay bump, and it directly signals finalisation and Indian GAAP competence.
2. **Prove you can close the books, not just record them.** In interviews, walk through a month-end close you owned: the accruals, the reconciliations, the schedules you handed the auditor.
3. **Show audit coordination experience.** Being able to say "I was the auditor's point of contact and cleared the audit with zero major observations" is powerful — it's what this role is judged on.
4. **Build an MIS pack.** A clean monthly management report (P&L vs budget, debtors/creditors ageing, cash position) that you designed shows you think like a manager, not a data-entry operator.

The single biggest differentiator: the ability to independently finalise a set of accounts and stand behind them in front of an auditor. Plenty of people can post entries; the person who can close, finalise, reconcile, and defend the books is the one who gets the manager title — and the salary that comes with it.

Accounts Payable (AP) Analyst

Snapshot

The Accounts Payable (AP) Analyst owns the *pay* side of the business — the Procure-to-Pay (P2P) cycle that turns a vendor invoice into a cleared payment. Where an SME Accountant does a bit of everything, the AP Analyst is a specialist in a large, process-driven environment: almost always a Global Capability Centre (GCC) or shared-services operation in Hyderabad, Bangalore, Pune, or Gurgaon, running on SAP or Oracle rather than Tally. You process high volumes of invoices, run three-way matches, reconcile vendor accounts, execute payment runs, and deduct TDS on payments — all against SLAs (service-level agreements) and strict close timelines. It sits within a larger finance operations team and reports to an AP Team Lead / Process Lead. The ladder: **AP Analyst → Senior AP Analyst → AP Team Lead / SME → AP Manager (P2P Tower Lead).** For a commerce graduate, GCC AP is one of the best-paying and most structured entry points into corporate finance — better pay and clearer progression than SME accounting, in exchange for depth over breadth.

What you'll actually do

Synthesised from real P2P / shared-services postings, the day-to-day is high-volume and process-disciplined:

- **Invoice processing** — receive, validate, code, and enter vendor invoices into SAP / Oracle accurately and within SLA.
- **Three-way match** — match each invoice to its purchase order (PO) and goods-receipt note (GRN); investigate and resolve mismatches and exceptions.
- **Vendor reconciliation** — reconcile vendor statements to the ledger, resolve disputes, and clear debit/credit balances.
- **Payment runs** — prepare and execute scheduled payment batches, ensure correct payment terms, and manage the payment proposal.
- Deduct and account for **TDS on vendor payments** and apply correct GST treatment on invoices.
- Handle **vendor queries** and the AP helpdesk within turnaround times.
- Perform **month-end AP close** activities — accruals for un-invoiced receipts, GR/IR reconciliation, and AP ageing reporting.
- Track and report on SLA/KPI metrics (invoices processed, exceptions, aged items).

> Real posting (shared-services P2P, e.g. Genpact/Accenture-type): "Process vendor invoices with three-way match against PO and GRN, perform vendor reconciliations, and support month-end close within agreed SLAs."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: invoice processing and P2P knowledge; three-way matching logic (PO–GRN–invoice); vendor reconciliation; TDS on payments and basic GST on purchases; ERP data entry accuracy; Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables) for reconciliations and ageing. **Soft skills:** speed with accuracy under high volume, SLA discipline, exception-handling and problem-solving, and clear written communication for vendor queries (often in English with global stakeholders). Comfort with **shifted or night hours** is frequently required in GCCs serving US/EU clients.

Tools & software

- **SAP** (FI/MM, often SAP S/4HANA) and **Oracle** — the dominant ERPs in GCC AP.
- **MS Excel** — VLOOKUP, PivotTables, reconciliations.
- Workflow/OCR tools such as **SAP VIM**, **Ariba**, **Coupa**, or **Tungsten/Basware** for invoice capture and approvals.
- Ticketing tools (e.g. **ServiceNow**) for vendor query management.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com is the standard; BBA/M.Com also accepted.
- **Certifications that help here:** an **SAP FICO** (or SAP MM/AP) familiarity is the strongest differentiator — even a short SAP course helps you clear screens. **CMA-Inter** signals fundamentals; global process certs matter less than hands-on ERP exposure.
- CA/CFA/FMVA are **not** what this role rewards — it values process precision and ERP fluency over analytical or valuation skills. Save those certs if your target is FP&A or analysis.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry	0–2 yrs	AP Analyst, P2P Associate, Accounts Payable Executive
Mid	2–5 yrs	Senior AP Analyst, P2P Specialist / SME
Senior	5–8 yrs	AP Team Lead, Process Lead, Assistant Manager – P2P

Freshers are hired directly into GCC AP; the process ladder is well-defined and promotions are relatively predictable.

ATS keywords to mirror

accounts payable, P2P, procure-to-pay, invoice processing, three-way match, PO, GRN, GR/IR, vendor reconciliation, payment run, TDS on payments, SAP, Oracle, SAP MM, SAP VIM, Ariba, Coupa, month-end close, AP ageing, SLA, exception handling, ERP, MS Excel

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0–2 yrs)	3.0 – 5.0
2–4 yrs	4.5 – 8.0
5–8 yrs	7.5 – 13.0

GCC AP typically pays more than SME accounting at the same experience level, and night-shift roles often add a shift allowance. Figures vary by city, employer, and shift, and are approximate.

Who's hiring

Global Capability Centres and shared-services/BPM firms — the biggest volume is in Hyderabad and Bangalore, with Pune, Gurgaon, and Chennai close behind. Real employers hiring P2P/AP roles on Indeed include **Accenture**, **Genpact**, **Amazon** (and its GCC finance operations), plus captive GCCs of global banks, manufacturers, and tech firms. Any large multinational running finance operations out of India has an AP tower.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Get SAP exposure.** Even a short SAP FICO or SAP MM course, or hands-on time in a sandbox, lets you speak the ERP language GCC recruiters screen for. It's the fastest way to stand out from other B.Com applicants.
2. **Understand three-way match cold.** Be able to explain, with an example, how an invoice, PO, and GRN reconcile — and how you'd resolve a quantity or price mismatch. This is the technical heart of the interview.
3. **Demonstrate speed-with-accuracy.** GCCs live on SLAs; show you can handle volume without errors (a clean Excel reconciliation exercise or data-entry accuracy example works well).
4. **Be honest about shifts.** Many roles serve US/EU clients; signalling comfort with night or rotational shifts removes a common objection.

The single biggest differentiator: hands-on ERP fluency (SAP/Oracle) plus a genuine grasp of the P2P exception workflow. Recruiters see hundreds of B.Com resumes that list "accounts payable"; the candidate who can actually navigate SAP, resolve a GR/IR mismatch, and talk SLAs is the one who gets hired — and who moves up the P2P tower fastest.

Accounts Receivable (AR) Analyst

Snapshot

An Accounts Receivable (AR) Analyst owns the "cash-in" half of a company's **Order-to-Cash (O2C)** cycle: turning delivered goods and services into invoices, chasing those invoices until the money lands, and matching the cash back to the right customer account. If AP (accounts payable) is about paying suppliers, AR is about **getting paid** — and because it directly feeds the bank balance, working capital and DSO (Days Sales Outstanding), it is one of the most visibility-heavy junior finance roles a company has. In India, AR sits inside two very different homes: the **finance shared-services / GCC and BPO world** (Genpact, Accenture, WNS, and captive centres of MNCs), where you process AR for a global parent under strict SLAs, and the **domestic company finance team** of any SME or mid-market firm, where AR is one hat among several. The typical ladder runs **Associate / Executive -> Senior Associate / Senior Executive -> Team Lead / Assistant Manager -> Manager (O2C) -> O2C Tower Lead**. Firms like Grant Thornton hire "Associate - Accounts Receivable" specifically for this function.

What you'll actually do

- Raise and issue customer **invoices** (and credit/debit notes) accurately, matching them to sales orders, delivery proof and contract terms — including correct GST treatment.
- Run **collections**: follow up on overdue accounts by email and call, send statements and dunning reminders, and negotiate payment timelines within credit policy.
- Perform **cash application** — match incoming receipts (NEFT/RTGS, cheques, portal payments) against open invoices, and clear the customer ledger.
- Maintain the **AR ageing** report (0-30 / 31-60 / 61-90 / 90+ buckets) and flag accounts slipping into higher-risk buckets.
- Track and report **DSO** and collection-effectiveness metrics; explain movements month over month.
- Handle **disputes and deductions** — short payments, pricing mismatches, quality claims — by coordinating with sales, logistics and the customer until resolved.
- Support **credit control**: review credit limits, escalate blocked orders, and recommend holds on chronic defaulters.
- Reconcile customer accounts, pass write-offs/provisions for bad debt, and provide AR schedules to auditors at close.

> Real posting (Grant Thornton): "Manage the accounts receivable process including invoicing, cash application, and collections follow-up, and maintain accurate ageing reports."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: double-entry accounting fundamentals; understanding of the full O2C flow; invoice-to-cash matching; ageing and DSO analysis; GST basics on outward supplies; bank reconciliation; Excel (VLOOKUP/XLOOKUP, PivotTables, SUMIFS) for ageing and reconciliation work.

Soft skills: the AR job is half accounting, half **polite persistence** — you need firm, professional communication to chase money without damaging customer relationships; negotiation for payment plans; cross-functional coordination with sales and operations; and attention to detail so a wrongly applied receipt doesn't snowball into a reconciliation mess. In GCC/BPO settings, **SLA discipline** and comfort with high transaction volumes matter as much as technical skill.

Tools & software

- **ERP / accounting:** SAP (FI-AR module), Oracle, Microsoft Dynamics, NetSuite, Zoho Books, and **Tally / TallyPrime** in SME shops.
- **Collections & O2C platforms:** HighRadius (very common in Indian GCCs), Blackline, GetPaid, or in-house dunning tools.
- **Excel** — the everyday workhorse for ageing, cash-app reconciliation and DSO tracking.
- **Reporting/BI:** Power BI or Tableau for AR dashboards in larger teams.
- Customer/vendor portals (Ariba, Coupa) for invoice submission at enterprise clients.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com / BBA is the standard entry credential; MBA-Finance helps for the manager track.
- **CA/CMA (inter)** candidates are welcomed and move up faster, but AR does **not** require a full qualification — it is one of the more accessible entries into corporate finance.
- **Certifications that actually help:** a short **SAP FICO** or **HighRadius O2C** certification is the single most marketable add-on for GCC roles. Advanced **Excel** certification is genuinely useful. CFA/FRM are overkill and not relevant here.
- For domestic SME roles, demonstrated **GST and TDS** familiarity beats any certificate.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	AR Associate, AR Executive, O2C Analyst	Process invoices, apply cash, run ageing under supervision
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior AR Associate, Senior Executive, Team Lead	Own a customer portfolio, drive collections, cut DSO, mentor juniors
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Assistant Manager / Manager - O2C, Collections Lead	Own SLAs, credit policy, team performance, client governance

ATS keywords to mirror

Accounts Receivable, AR, Order-to-Cash, O2C, invoicing, cash application, collections, AR ageing, DSO, Days Sales Outstanding, credit control, dispute resolution, deductions, bank reconciliation, SAP FI-AR, HighRadius, GST, customer reconciliation, SLA, bad-debt provision, dunning, working capital.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	2.5 - 4.5
2-4 yrs	4.5 - 7
5-8 yrs (Sr / AM)	7 - 12

Approximate; varies materially by city (Bangalore/Gurugram/Hyderabad GCCs pay more than SME domestic roles), employer type and shift (night-shift/US-process roles carry allowances).

Who's hiring

- **Professional-services / GCC:** Grant Thornton (Associate - AR), Genpact, Accenture, WNS, EXL, Capgemini.
- **MNC captives:** shared-service centres of large manufacturers, tech and consumer firms running global O2C from India.
- **Domestic mid-market & SME:** any company with a sizeable customer book — manufacturers, distributors, IT services, healthcare.
- The **BPO/GCC belt** (Bangalore, Hyderabad, Gurugram, Pune, Chennai) is where the volume of AR openings concentrates.

How to break in / stand out

For a commerce or MBA-Finance candidate, AR is one of the **friendliest doors into corporate finance** — high hiring volume, forgiving on prior experience, and a clear path upward. To stand out:

1. **Build a mock AR/O2C portfolio in Excel:** take a fictional customer set, generate invoices, build a working ageing report with automatic bucketing (formulas, not manual), compute DSO, and show a collections tracker. This proves you understand the mechanics before day one.
2. **Learn one collections platform** — even the free HighRadius academy content — and put it on your resume. GCC recruiters screen hard for HighRadius/SAP exposure.
3. **Speak the metrics language:** be able to explain DSO, collection effectiveness index and ageing buckets in an interview, and how you'd cut DSO by 5 days.

The **single biggest differentiator** is showing you treat AR as a **cash-flow lever, not data entry** — a candidate who can articulate how faster collections free up working capital, and who backs it with an ageing model they actually built, instantly reads as promotable to Team Lead rather than a processor.

Record-to-Report (R2R) / General Ledger Analyst

Snapshot

The Record-to-Report (R2R) — or **General Ledger (GL)** — Analyst is the person who actually **closes the books**. Where AR and AP handle transactions, R2R sits one layer up: it posts the month-end journals, reconciles every balance-sheet account, explains the numbers, and hands clean, audit-ready schedules to the controllers and auditors. This is the **core finance role of India's GCC / shared-services economy** — the single largest category of "real accounting" jobs being created in the country, because global companies run their group close from Bangalore, Gurugram, Hyderabad, Pune and Chennai. R2R is where a commerce graduate or part-qualified CA/CMA learns the machinery of a real close under hard deadlines. The ladder typically runs **Analyst / Executive -> Senior Analyst -> Team Lead / Assistant Manager -> R2R / GL Manager -> Controllership / Tower Lead**. Firms like Cromwell hire R2R analysts to run exactly this month-end engine.

What you'll actually do

- Post **month-end journals**: accruals, prepayments, provisions, payroll journals, intercompany charges, fixed-asset entries, depreciation and reclassifications.
- Prepare **balance-sheet reconciliations** with **commentary and ageing** — not just tie the number, but explain what sits in the account and why open items are aged.
- Perform **intercompany reconciliation** and settlement, chasing mismatches between group entities.
- Run **fixed-asset accounting** — capitalisation, depreciation runs, disposals and the FA register.
- Track the close against **working-day (WD) timelines** — "WD+3", "WD+5" — meaning each task has a fixed day in the close calendar it must be finished by.
- Produce **schedules for audit, tax and statutory** reporting, and respond to auditor queries.
- Do **variance analysis** — flux commentary explaining why an account moved versus prior month or budget.
- Maintain the integrity of the **general ledger**, ensuring postings hit the right cost centre, entity and GL code.

> Real posting (Cromwell): "Prepare month-end journals including accruals, prepayments and provisions, and complete balance-sheet reconciliations with commentary and ageing within the working-day close timeline."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: solid **double-entry** and accrual-accounting foundation; the mechanics of a month-end close; balance-sheet reconciliation and open-item ageing; journal preparation across all major categories; fixed-asset accounting and depreciation; variance/flux analysis; familiarity with **Ind AS / IFRS / local GAAP** concepts (which framework depends on the parent). Strong **Excel** is non-negotiable — this role lives in reconciliation templates.

Soft skills: discipline under a fixed close calendar; accuracy (a wrong journal reverses next month and annoys auditors); clear written commentary — R2R analysts must *explain* numbers, so business writing matters; and coordination with AP, AR, treasury and tax teams whose data feeds the GL.

Tools & software

- **ERP:** SAP (FI/CO — the dominant one in GCCs), Oracle Fusion/EBS, Microsoft Dynamics, NetSuite; **Tally/Zoho** at smaller Indian firms.
- **Reconciliation & close tools:** BlackLine and Trintech Cadency (industry-standard for balance-sheet recon and close orchestration), FloQast.
- **Excel** — the daily reconciliation and schedule-building workhorse.
- **BI:** Power BI / Tableau for close dashboards and flux reporting in mature teams.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com is the baseline; the role explicitly welcomes candidates **studying towards an accountancy qualification**.
- **CA / CMA (inter or final), ACCA** — these are the credentials that accelerate you toward controllership. A part-qualified CA/CMA is the sweet-spot profile for a GCC R2R team.
- **SAP FICO certification** is the most valuable practical add-on and a genuine resume differentiator for these roles.
- **CPA / ACCA** help specifically at US- and UK-parent GCCs. CFA/FRM are not relevant to R2R.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	R2R Analyst, GL Executive, Accounting Analyst	Post routine journals, do recons under review
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior R2R Analyst, GL Team Lead	Own a close area, sign off recons, write flux commentary
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Assistant Manager / Manager - R2R, Controllership Analyst	Own the close calendar, review team output, face auditors

ATS keywords to mirror

Record to Report, R2R, General Ledger, GL, month-end close, journal entries, accruals, prepayments, provisions, intercompany, fixed assets, depreciation, balance-sheet reconciliation, ageing, commentary, variance analysis, flux, working-day close, WD+3, Ind AS, IFRS, GAAP, SAP FICO, BlackLine, statutory schedules, audit support.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	3 - 5.5
2-4 yrs	5.5 - 9
5-8 yrs (Sr / AM)	9 - 16

Approximate; part-qualified/qualified CAs and SAP-skilled candidates sit at the top of each band. GCC captives generally pay above BPO third-party providers; night-shift US-process roles add allowances.

Who's hiring

- **GCC captives & shared services:** Cromwell, plus the India finance centres of virtually every global MNC (tech, manufacturing, consumer, pharma).
- **Third-party BPO providers:** Genpact, Accenture, Capgemini, WNS, EXL, Cognizant — running R2R for multiple clients.
- Domestic mid-to-large companies for their central accounting/close teams.
- Concentrated in the **Bangalore-Hyderabad-Gurugram-Pune-Chennai** GCC corridor.

How to break in / stand out

R2R is the **highest-leverage learning role** for a young Indian finance professional — it teaches you the entire close and sets up a clean path to controllership. To break in:

1. **Build a month-end close simulation:** take a trial balance, prepare a full set of journals (accruals, prepayments, depreciation, intercompany), then produce a balance-sheet reconciliation pack **with ageing and commentary**. This one artifact demonstrates you understand the whole cycle, not just entries.
2. **Get hands-on with SAP** — even a training instance or a certification. GCC recruiters filter on SAP FICO exposure more than on grades.
3. **Practise writing flux commentary** — pick two periods, explain the movement in plain business English. The ability to *narrate* numbers is what separates a Senior Analyst from a processor.

The **single biggest differentiator** is showing you can **own an account end-to-end** — post it, reconcile it, age it, explain it, and defend it to an auditor. A candidate who arrives already fluent in WD-close discipline and reconciliation commentary is exactly what every GCC controller is short of.

Tax Analyst (Direct & Indirect / GST-TDS)

Snapshot

A Tax Analyst keeps a company **compliant with the tax code** — computing what's owed, filing returns on time, reconciling tax ledgers, and answering the department's notices. In India the role splits along two axes. On the **subject-matter** axis it covers **direct tax** (income tax, TDS/TCS, advance tax) and **indirect tax** (GST — returns, reconciliation, input-tax credit). On the **employer** axis it splits between **domestic India-tax roles** (SME finance teams, Indian companies, CA firms — where you file GST and TDS hands-on) and **global-tax GCC roles** at MNC captives and banks like Citi, where you manage the tax compliance and reporting of a foreign parent across multiple jurisdictions. Both start junior and climb: **Tax Analyst / Executive -> Senior Analyst -> Assistant Manager (Tax) -> Tax Manager -> Head of Tax / Tax Controller**. Citi's "Tax Analyst" opening is a textbook GCC entry point.

What you'll actually do

- Prepare and file **GST returns** (GSTR-1, GSTR-3B) and perform **GSTR-2B / input-tax-credit reconciliation** against the books and vendor filings.
- Compute and deposit **TDS / TCS**, file quarterly TDS returns (24Q/26Q), issue Form 16/16A, and reconcile with Form 26AS.
- Prepare **income-tax computations**, advance-tax workings and support **corporate income-tax filing** (in GCC roles, across multiple jurisdictions).
- Manage **tax liabilities, compliance and financial reporting** — maintain tax provisions, deferred tax and tax GLs, and support tax disclosures at close.
- Track the **compliance calendar** so no return or payment is missed.
- Respond to **notices, assessments and department queries**; assemble documentation for scrutiny and audits.
- Support **tax audits and transfer-pricing** documentation in larger organisations.
- Work with risk/controls to keep tax processes within policy.

> Real posting (Citi): "Manage tax liabilities of the organisation, including compliance, financial reporting and filing, and assist with income-tax filing across jurisdictions."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: working knowledge of the **Income-Tax Act** and **GST law**; TDS/TCS provisions and rates; GST return mechanics and ITC reconciliation; income-tax computation and provisioning; deferred-tax basics; strong **Excel** for reconciliations; **financial acumen** and management-reporting sense (called out explicitly by Citi).

Soft skills: precision and deadline discipline (tax dates are statutory and unforgiving); the ability to read and interpret law and circulars; clear drafting for notice responses; and coordination with accounts, AP and auditors. In global-tax roles, comfort with **multiple jurisdictions and ambiguity** matters.

Tools & software

- **Compliance software:** ClearTax, Zoho, TallyPrime, Winman, Genius, and the government portals — **GSTN** and **TRACES** — for filing and reconciliation.
- **ERP:** SAP, Oracle, NetSuite, Tally for the underlying tax GLs.
- **Global-tax tools:** OneSource (Thomson Reuters), Vertex, CorpTax at MNC captives.
- **Excel** for every reconciliation, computation and provision working.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com is the entry credential.
- **CA** is the gold standard for a tax career — a CA with a tax focus commands the strongest path to Tax Manager and beyond. **CMA** is well regarded, especially for indirect tax and cost-linked compliance.
- **CS** helps where tax overlaps with secretarial/regulatory compliance.
- Specialist certificates — ICAI's **Certificate Course on GST**, or a **Diploma in Taxation** — are genuinely useful for B.Com candidates without a full qualification.
- For **global-tax GCC** roles, **CPA / ACCA / EA** (US Enrolled Agent) can matter depending on the parent's jurisdiction. CFA/FRM are not relevant here.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	Tax Analyst, Tax Executive, GST/TDS Executive	Prepare returns, reconcile ITC/26AS under review
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior Tax Analyst, Assistant Manager - Tax	Own filings end-to-end, draft notice responses, handle assessments
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Tax Manager, Tax Controller	Own tax strategy, provisions, audits, transfer pricing

ATS keywords to mirror

Tax Analyst, direct tax, indirect tax, GST, GSTR-1, GSTR-3B, GSTR-2B reconciliation, input tax credit, ITC, TDS, TCS, 24Q, 26Q, Form 26AS, TRACES, income-tax computation, advance tax, tax compliance, tax reporting, deferred tax, tax provision, notices, assessment, transfer pricing, ClearTax, SAP, compliance calendar.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	3 - 5
2-4 yrs	5 - 9
5-8 yrs (AM / Manager)	9 - 18

Approximate; a qualified CA in a specialist tax role sits well above these ranges. Global-tax GCC roles (Citi-type) generally pay above domestic SME tax jobs; the band widens sharply with CA + specialisation.

Who's hiring

- **Banks & financial GCCs:** Citi and peer captives running global tax from Mumbai/Bangalore.
- **Big 4 & CA firms:** Deloitte, PwC, EY, KPMG, and mid-tier/local CA firms — the classic tax training ground.
- **Corporate tax teams** of Indian and MNC companies across sectors.
- **SMEs** needing hands-on GST/TDS filers (often B.Com + CA-inter profiles).

How to break in / stand out

Tax is a **specialist track that rewards depth** — and because the law changes constantly, demonstrated currency beats a stale degree. For a commerce/MBA-Finance candidate:

1. **File real returns** — even for a small business, a family firm, or via an internship at a CA office. Nothing beats having actually filed GSTR-3B and a TDS return on the live portals.
2. **Do the ICAI GST certificate or a taxation diploma** and build a **GST reconciliation workbook** (books vs GSTR-2B, with mismatch flags) as a portfolio piece — this is exactly the day-one task.
3. **Follow the law actively** — track Budget changes, CBDT/CBIC circulars and key GST notifications, and be able to discuss a recent change in an interview.

The **single biggest differentiator** is showing you can **turn law into a filed return and defend it in a notice reply** — a candidate who has actually reconciled ITC, computed TDS and drafted a response to a department query is worth far more than one who has only read the Act. For the highest ceiling, pair tax depth with a **CA**.

Audit Associate (Statutory & Internal)

Snapshot

An Audit Associate examines whether an organisation's financial statements are **true and fair** (statutory audit) and whether its processes and controls actually **work** (internal audit). It is the classic proving ground of the accounting profession: for most Indian CAs the journey begins as an **article assistant** in a CA firm doing statutory audits, and many later move into **industry internal-audit and controllership** teams. Statutory audit is an external, opinion-giving exercise governed by law and auditing standards; internal audit is an inside-the-business assurance function focused on risk, controls and process improvement. The two share a toolkit — sampling, documentation, control testing — but differ in purpose. The ladder in a firm runs **Article / Audit Associate -> Senior Associate -> Assistant Manager -> Manager -> Partner**; in industry it runs **Internal Audit Associate -> Senior -> AM -> Manager -> Head of Internal Audit**. Fintech and product companies like Plum hire audit/controllership staff to run exactly this assurance-plus-close work.

What you'll actually do

- Execute **statutory audit** procedures under **Ind AS / Indian GAAP** — vouching, verification, analytical review, and testing account balances against evidence.
- Test **internal financial controls (IFC)** and, for US-linked entities, **SOX** controls — walkthroughs, design and operating-effectiveness testing.
- Perform **process / operational audits** in internal audit — map a process, identify risks, test controls, and recommend improvements.
- Prepare **audit documentation and working papers** that stand up to review — the discipline of "if it isn't documented, it wasn't done".
- Assist the **month/quarter/annual close** and preparation of **financial statements** in controllership-flavoured roles.
- Verify **3-way and bank reconciliations**, GST/TDS/income-tax compliance, and schedules supporting the accounts.
- Draft **audit findings and observations**, quantify impact, and follow up on management action plans.
- Support **statutory, tax and internal audits** end-to-end, coordinating with the client/business and the engagement senior.

> Real posting (Plum): "Assist with statutory, tax and internal audits, prepare financial statements under Indian GAAP, and support internal financial controls."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: strong grounding in **Ind AS / Indian GAAP** and the **Standards on Auditing (SA)**; internal-control and risk concepts (IFC/SOX); audit sampling and evidence; financial-statement preparation and analysis; reconciliation (3-way, bank); working knowledge of GST/TDS/income tax; **Excel** for testing and analytics.

Soft skills: professional scepticism — the instinct to ask "how do I know this is true?"; meticulous documentation; integrity and independence; the communication skill to raise findings tactfully and defend them; and the stamina to work long hours during busy season (year-end statutory audits are brutal).

Tools & software

- **Audit tools:** CaseWare, MindBridge, and firm-proprietary audit software; ICAI's audit tools for smaller firms.
- **ERP / accounting:** SAP, Oracle, **Zoho** (used by Plum-type firms), Tally, NetSuite — you audit the ledgers that live here.
- **Excel** — the universal working-paper and testing tool (PivotTables, lookups, sampling).
- **GRC / controls platforms:** AuditBoard, ServiceNow GRC, TeamMate for internal-audit shops.
- Data-analytics tools (Power BI, ACL/IDEA) increasingly used for full-population testing.

Qualifications & certifications

- **CA** is the defining credential — statutory audit is legally the domain of Chartered Accountants, and the article-assistant route is how you enter. **CA-inter + articleship** is the working profile of most audit associates.
- **CMA, ACCA, CPA** are valuable, especially ACCA/CPA for MNC internal-audit and controllership roles.
- **CIA (Certified Internal Auditor)** is the premier global credential specifically for **internal audit** careers.
- **CISA** helps where audit meets IT/systems; **DISA** (ICAI) for IS-audit in the Indian context.
- CFA/FRM are peripheral here — this is an accounting-and-controls role, not a markets one.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher / article (0-2 yrs)	Article Assistant, Audit Associate, IA Associate	Execute test procedures, prepare working papers under review
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior Associate, Internal Audit Senior	Lead sections/engagements, review juniors, draft findings
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Assistant Manager / Manager - Audit / IA	Own engagements, client/stakeholder management, quality sign-off

ATS keywords to mirror

Statutory audit, internal audit, Ind AS, Indian GAAP, Standards on Auditing, internal financial controls, IFC, SOX, risk-based audit, control testing, walkthrough, audit documentation, working papers, financial statements, month-end close, 3-way reconciliation, bank reconciliation, GST, TDS, audit findings, process audit, CaseWare, CA, professional scepticism.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher / freshly qualified CA	7 - 12
2-4 yrs (post-qualification)	12 - 20
5-8 yrs (Manager)	20 - 35+

Approximate; qualified-CA figures shown. Article-assistant stipends are far lower (a few thousand rupees/month). Big 4 and industry controllership pay above smaller firms; semi-qualified/non-CA internal-audit roles sit below these CA bands.

Who's hiring

- **Big 4 & audit firms:** Deloitte, PwC, EY, KPMG, BDO, Grant Thornton, plus thousands of mid-tier and local CA firms (the articleship engine).
- **Industry internal audit / controllership:** Plum and other fintechs, plus internal-audit teams across manufacturing, banking, IT and consumer sectors.
- **GCC assurance & controls teams** of MNCs running SOX/IFC testing from India.
- Regulators and PSUs for internal-audit functions.

How to break in / stand out

Audit is the **most structured entry** into elite finance careers — but the front door for statutory work is genuinely the **CA articleship**. To break in and stand out:

1. **Do articleship at a firm with real audit exposure** (or a strong internal-audit internship if you're not on the CA track) — hands-on statutory audit experience is the credential employers actually trust.
2. **Master Ind AS and the Standards on Auditing cold**, and build a sample **audit working-paper file** for one account cycle (say, revenue or fixed assets) — walkthrough, risk, control test, conclusion. It shows you understand the *method*, not just the theory.
3. **Learn control frameworks** (IFC/COSO, and SOX if you target MNCs) and one data-analytics tool — full-population testing is where modern audit is heading.

The **single biggest differentiator** is demonstrable **professional scepticism plus airtight documentation** — a candidate who can explain how they'd test an assertion, what evidence would satisfy them, and how they'd document it, reads as a real auditor. Pair that with the **CA** (or **CIA** for a pure internal-audit path) and you have the strongest, most durable credential in Indian finance.

Payroll & Compliance Executive

Snapshot

The Payroll & Compliance Executive is the person who makes sure every employee is paid the right amount, on the right day, with the right deductions — and that the company stays on the right side of India's statutory machinery (PF, ESI, Professional Tax, TDS on salary, labour-law returns). It sits at the intersection of Finance, HR, and Compliance. In smaller firms it lives inside the HR or accounts team; in large GCCs and BPOs it is a dedicated "Payroll Operations" function running for external clients under strict SLAs. This is a process-heavy, deadline-driven, accuracy-obsessed role — a single wrong PF number can trigger a notice, and a missed pay-run erodes employee trust instantly. The ladder typically runs Payroll Executive/Associate -> Sr Payroll Executive -> Payroll Team Lead/SME -> Assistant Manager Payroll -> Payroll Manager -> Payroll Operations Lead. In global-payroll GCC setups (Accenture, Genpact, ADP, TCS) you also see "Payroll Analyst" and "Specialist" titles that own a country or region.

What you'll actually do

- Run the monthly payroll cycle end to end: collect inputs (attendance, leave, new joiners, exits, arrears, incentives), process gross-to-net, and release salaries within the pay-run SLA.
- Compute and deduct statutory items: Provident Fund (12% EPF), ESI (where wages ≤ Rs 21,000), Professional Tax (state-wise slabs), and TDS on salary under the correct tax regime.
- File and deposit statutory dues on time: PF/ESI challans (ECR), PT returns, and quarterly TDS returns (Form 24Q); issue Form 16 at year-end.
- Reconcile payroll: month-on-month variance analysis, headcount vs cost reconciliation, GL-to-payroll tie-outs, and reconciling statutory registers against challans paid.
- Handle full-and-final settlements for exits — gratuity, leave encashment, notice recovery, and clawbacks.
- Produce payroll reports for internal finance and for authorities; support statutory and internal audits with registers and evidence.
- In GCC/global-payroll roles: run payroll for one or more countries, coordinate with in-country partners, manage vendor SLAs, and meet tight cut-off calendars.

> Real posting (Accenture): "Payroll processing, statutory deductions and social security; reconciliations and variance analysis; prepare payroll reports for authorities within agreed SLAs."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: end-to-end payroll processing; solid grasp of PF, ESI, PT, TDS-on-salary and gratuity/bonus rules; gross-to-net logic; reconciliation and variance analysis; and strong Excel (VLOOKUP/XLOOKUP, PivotTables, SUMIFS, IF-nesting for slab logic). Understanding of the old vs new tax regime and how it changes salary TDS is now essential. Soft skills the JDs repeat: confidentiality (you see everyone's salary), accuracy under deadline pressure, SLA discipline, and clear communication when an employee disputes a payslip. In global-payroll roles, comfort with multiple country rules and time-zone coordination matters.

Tools & software

- **Payroll/HRMS:** greytHR, Zoho Payroll, Keka, Darwinbox, RazorpayX Payroll (India SMEs/mid-market); SAP SuccessFactors/SAP Payroll, ADP GlobalView/Celergo, Ceridian, Workday for large/global setups.
- **Statutory portals:** EPFO Unified Portal (ECR), ESIC portal, state PT portals, TRACES and the Income-Tax e-filing portal for 24Q/Form 16.
- **Spreadsheets & reporting:** advanced Excel is non-negotiable; Power BI/Tableau for payroll dashboards in larger teams.
- **Ticketing/SLA:** ServiceNow or similar for case management in BPO/GCC payroll ops.

Qualifications & certifications

A B.Com (or BBA/M.Com) is the standard base; Accenture's posting asks for B.Com with 3+ years. No single "payroll certification" is mandatory in India, but these genuinely help: a diploma in payroll/labour laws or HR-payroll, CA-Inter or CMA-Inter (signals statutory and reconciliation strength), and for global roles the **CPP (Certified Payroll Professional)** or **FPC** from the American Payroll Association, plus **CIPP** (UK) for UK-payroll GCC teams. An MBA-HR or MBA-Finance can accelerate the move into a Payroll Manager seat. Knowledge of the four new Labour Codes (as they roll out) is increasingly a differentiator.

Experience & typical titles

- **Fresher / 0-2 yrs:** Payroll Associate, Payroll Executive, Payroll Trainee — you own inputs, run checks, and prepare challans under supervision.
- **2-4 yrs:** Sr Payroll Executive, Payroll Analyst, Payroll Specialist — you run full cycles independently, file statutory returns, and handle F&F.
- **5-8 yrs:** Payroll Team Lead, Payroll SME, Assistant Manager Payroll — you own an SLA/client or country, manage juniors, and face audits.

ATS keywords to mirror

Payroll processing, statutory compliance, PF, ESI, Professional Tax, TDS on salary, Form 24Q, Form 16, gross-to-net, EPFO ECR, ESIC, gratuity, full and final settlement, payroll reconciliation, variance analysis, SLA, greytHR, Zoho Payroll, SAP Payroll, ADP, labour law compliance, social security, global payroll, statutory deductions, payroll audit.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	2.5 – 4.5
2-4 yrs	4.5 – 8
5-8 yrs	8 – 15

Global-payroll GCC roles and Payroll Manager seats sit at the upper end; pure India-payroll SME roles at the lower. Varies by city and employer; figures are approximate.

Who's hiring

Big GCCs and BPOs run large payroll-ops factories: **Accenture**, Genpact, TCS, Infosys BPM, Wipro, ADP, and Deloitte/EY managed-payroll teams — these dominate the global-payroll GCC variant. On the India-payroll side, every mid-to-large corporate has an in-house payroll team, and specialist providers (greytHR, Zoho, RazorpayX, Keka, PazCare) hire payroll executives to run client books. SMEs fold payroll into the accounts function, so an Accounts Executive who owns payroll is common in Hyderabad/Bangalore firms.

How to break in / stand out

Start by mastering the statutory triad — PF, ESI, PT — plus salary-TDS under both tax regimes, because that knowledge is what separates a data-entry clerk from a real payroll professional. Build a portfolio project: take a mock 50-employee company, build a full gross-to-net payroll workbook in Excel with automated PF/ESI/PT/TDS logic, a variance report, and a set of challan-ready outputs — this single artifact proves more than any bullet point. Learn one modern HRMS (greytHR or Zoho Payroll) hands-on; free trials exist. **The single biggest differentiator is zero-error, on-time delivery under SLA** — payroll is judged on reliability, so a candidate who can talk credibly about cut-off calendars, reconciliation checks, and how they caught an error before pay-out instantly stands out. For the GCC path, add one country's payroll rules (UK or US) and the CPP/CIPP credential to jump from India-payroll to global-payroll pay bands.

Financial Analyst

Snapshot

"Financial Analyst" is the most elastic title in finance — it can mean anyone who turns financial data into decisions. In practice, at asset managers and large financial firms it means a reporting-and-analysis specialist: someone who validates data, builds reports, and surfaces risks and trends for the business. The Franklin Templeton posting is a clean example — AUM and fund-flow reporting, validating asset data, and analysing it for risk and trends, using Power BI, VBA, Power Automate, Alteryx and Excel. This is a data-heavy, tooling-forward role that sits inside Finance, Operations, or a dedicated MIS/analytics team. It is *not* the same as FP&A (which is forward-looking planning) — the Financial Analyst is often reporting-and-insight on existing data, though the lines blur. The ladder runs Analyst -> Sr Analyst -> Assistant Manager -> Manager -> AVP/VP in banks and AMCs. Because the title is so broad, always read the JD: the tools and the "what you'll analyse" lines tell you which flavour it really is.

What you'll actually do

- Produce recurring financial and business reports: AUM, fund flows, revenue, cost, and KPI dashboards — daily, weekly, monthly.
- Validate and reconcile source data before it hits a report: check asset data, catch breaks, and ensure numbers tie across systems.
- Analyse the data for risk, trends, and anomalies — spot the outlier flow, the margin drift, the ageing exposure — and flag it to the business.
- Automate the grunt work: build repeatable pipelines in Alteryx/Power Automate and macros in VBA so reports refresh with less manual effort.
- Build and maintain Power BI dashboards and self-service views for stakeholders.
- Support ad-hoc analysis requests from management, and partner with ops/finance teams on data quality.
- In global-firm setups this often runs on a shift aligned to the parent market (the Franklin role is a 2-11pm night shift out of Hyderabad).

> Real posting (Franklin Templeton): "Report on AUM and flows, validate asset data, and analyse it for risk and trends — using Power BI, VBA, Power Automate, Alteryx and Excel."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: advanced Excel (PivotTables, complex formulas, Power Query); data validation and reconciliation instinct; at least one BI tool (Power BI most common); and increasingly an automation/ETL tool (Alteryx, Power Automate) plus VBA or SQL. The ability to *read* numbers — to look at a report and know which figure is wrong or interesting — is the core skill, and it's harder than the tooling. Basic accounting and financial-statement literacy is assumed. Soft skills the JDs demand: attention to detail, ability to translate data into a clear one-line insight for non-analysts, and reliability on a reporting calendar.

Tools & software

- **Excel** — still the backbone; expect Power Query and heavy formula work.
- **Power BI / Tableau** — dashboarding and visual reporting.
- **Alteryx, Power Automate** — data prep and workflow automation.
- **VBA, SQL, Python** — automation and pulling/reshaping data; Python is a rising "nice to have".
- **Source systems** — depending on employer: portfolio/fund accounting systems (AMCs), SAP/Oracle (corporates), Bloomberg/Refinitiv (data feeds).

Qualifications & certifications

The base is a bachelor's — B.Com, BBA, economics, or similar; many roles are open to freshers or 0-2 yrs. An MBA-Finance strengthens the profile and is often preferred for the analysis-heavy versions. Certifications that genuinely help depend on the flavour: **CFA** (or CFA Level 1) for investment/asset-management analyst roles; **NISM** series for capital-markets employers; and for the tooling side, a **Power BI (PL-300)** or **Alteryx Designer Core** certification is a concrete resume booster because these roles are explicit about tools. **FMVA** helps if the role tilts toward modelling. Certifications matter less here than a demonstrable ability to build a dashboard and validate data.

Experience & typical titles

- **Fresher / 0-2 yrs:** Financial Analyst, Data/Reporting Analyst, MIS Analyst, Business Analyst (Finance).
- **2-4 yrs:** Sr Financial Analyst, Reporting Analyst, Fund Reporting Analyst.
- **5-8 yrs:** Assistant Manager / Manager – Financial Reporting or Analytics, MIS Lead.

ATS keywords to mirror

Financial analysis, financial reporting, data validation, reconciliation, AUM reporting, fund flows, trend analysis, risk analysis, Power BI, Alteryx, Power Automate, VBA, advanced Excel, Power Query, SQL, KPI reporting, MIS, dashboards, variance analysis, data quality, management reporting.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	4 – 7
2-4 yrs	7 – 13
5-8 yrs	13 – 22

AMCs, global banks, and product firms pay at the upper end (and shift allowances add up); corporate MIS roles sit lower. Approximate; varies by city and employer.

Who's hiring

Asset managers and global financial firms are the classic home — **Franklin Templeton**, plus AMCs, Fidelity, BlackRock/Aladdin teams, and fund-admin shops (State Street, BNY, Northern Trust) in

Hyderabad/Bangalore/Pune. Global banks (Citi, HSBC, Barclays, JPMorgan GCCs) hire reporting and data analysts in bulk. Beyond finance firms, every large corporate and consulting/BPO (Genpact, Accenture, EY) has "Financial Analyst" roles doing reporting and analysis.

How to break in / stand out

This is one of the most accessible finance roles for a commerce/MBA candidate *if* you can prove you handle data, not just theory. Build a portfolio: take a public dataset (mutual-fund AUM data, or a company's segment financials) and build a Power BI dashboard that validates the data and surfaces one genuine trend or risk — publish it, and put the link on your resume. Layer on one automation project (an Alteryx workflow or a VBA macro that turns a manual report into a one-click refresh). **The single biggest differentiator is the ability to turn a messy data extract into a clean, validated dashboard with a one-sentence insight** — because the title is crowded, the candidate who shows a working artifact beats the one who only lists Excel. Learn to explain *why* a number moved, not just *that* it moved; that judgement is what earns the promotion to Senior Analyst and beyond.

FP&A Analyst

Snapshot

FP&A — Financial Planning & Analysis — is the premium back-office finance role: the team that owns budgets, forecasts, and the "why did we miss the number?" conversation with leadership. Where an accountant records what happened and a Financial Analyst reports on it, FP&A looks *forward* — building the annual budget, re-forecasting through the year, modelling scenarios, and explaining variance of actuals against plan to management. It sits close to decision-makers (CFO, business heads, unit controllers) and is the classic launchpad to Finance Manager, FP&A Manager, and eventually FP&A Lead / Finance Business Partner / Head of FP&A. In India this role is huge inside GCCs and BPO finance towers (Genpact, Accenture) as well as in-house corporate finance teams. It commands better pay and prestige than transactional roles precisely because it blends financial modelling, business judgement, and executive communication. The ladder: FP&A Analyst -> Sr FP&A Analyst -> Assistant Manager -> Manager FP&A -> Sr Manager / FP&A Lead -> Finance Business Partner / Director FP&A.

What you'll actually do

- Own the budgeting and forecasting cycle: build the annual operating plan (AOP), run quarterly re-forecasts, and consolidate inputs from business units.
- Perform variance analysis — actuals vs budget vs forecast vs prior year — and write the commentary that explains the drivers to management.
- Build and maintain financial models: revenue and cost drivers, scenario and sensitivity analysis, and headcount/capex plans.
- Produce management reporting: monthly business reviews, KPI decks, and board/leadership packs in Excel and PowerPoint.
- Partner with business owners to challenge assumptions, track spend against plan, and support decisions (pricing, hiring, investment).
- Pull actuals from the ERP (SAP/Oracle) and feed the planning tool (Anaplan/Hyperion), maintaining data integrity across systems.
- In BPO/GCC setups, this can involve R2R-adjacent tasks and running FP&A processes for a specific region or client.

> Real posting (Accenture / Genpact): "Budgeting, forecasting, variance analysis against actuals, financial modelling, and preparing KPI and management reports; SAP/Oracle/Anaplan/Hyperion, Power BI/Tableau."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: financial modelling (the real differentiator — driver-based models, scenario analysis, three-statement thinking); expert Excel (INDEX-MATCH/XLOOKUP, dynamic arrays, complex modelling, Power Query); strong variance analysis and the ability to write crisp business commentary; and PowerPoint storytelling for leadership decks. Familiarity with a planning tool (Anaplan or Hyperion/Oracle EPM) and an ERP (SAP/Oracle) is repeatedly demanded at 3-5 yrs. Soft skills that make or break FP&A: business acumen (understanding *what drives* the numbers, not just the numbers), the ability to influence non-finance stakeholders, and executive-level communication — turning a 40-tab model into a three-bullet takeaway.

Tools & software

- **Excel & PowerPoint** — the core modelling and reporting toolkit; mastery is assumed.
- **ERP:** SAP, Oracle — source of actuals.
- **EPM / planning:** Anaplan, Oracle Hyperion/EPM, SAP BPC, Workday Adaptive — budgeting and consolidation.
- **BI:** Power BI, Tableau — dashboards and KPI reporting.
- **Rising skills:** SQL and Python for pulling and automating large-data analysis.

Qualifications & certifications

A bachelor's in commerce/finance is the base, but FP&A is where postgraduate and professional qualifications pay off. **MBA-Finance, CA, or CMA** are all explicitly "a plus" in these JDs, and the best FP&A profiles usually carry one. **CMA (US or ICAI-Cost)** is especially well-aligned — cost, planning, and management accounting are the discipline's core. **CFA** helps in FP&A roles at financial firms or those tilting toward corporate finance/valuation. **FMVA** is a genuinely useful signal for the modelling skill at the analyst rung. For the tooling, an **Anaplan** or **Power BI (PL-300)** certification stands out because these platforms are named directly in postings.

Experience & typical titles

- **Fresher / 0-2 yrs:** FP&A Analyst, Financial Planning Analyst — usually MBA/CA freshers; you own data pulls, model maintenance, and variance schedules.
- **2-4 yrs:** Sr FP&A Analyst, FP&A Specialist — you own a business unit's forecast and commentary end to end.
- **5-8 yrs:** Assistant Manager / Manager FP&A, Finance Business Partner — you own the planning cycle, present to leadership, and manage analysts.

ATS keywords to mirror

FP&A, financial planning and analysis, budgeting, forecasting, variance analysis, financial modelling, management reporting, KPI reporting, annual operating plan, re-forecast, scenario analysis, driver-based modelling, actuals vs budget, SAP, Oracle, Anaplan, Hyperion, Power BI, Tableau, advanced Excel, business partnering, MIS.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	6 – 10
2-4 yrs	10 – 18
5-8 yrs	18 – 32

FP&A pays a clear premium over transactional finance. GCCs, MNC captives, and product firms sit at the top of each band; BPO FP&A towers a notch lower. Approximate; varies by city and employer.

Who's hiring

GCCs and BPO finance towers are the biggest recruiters: **Accenture, Genpact, Signode**, plus Deloitte/EY/KPMG managed-finance, and captive centres of MNCs (Amazon, Microsoft, Walmart, Philips, Shell) that run FP&A out of Bangalore/Hyderabad/Gurgaon/Pune. Every large Indian and multinational corporate has an in-house FP&A team. Product and tech companies (start-up to unicorn) hire FP&A analysts to run investor and board reporting.

How to break in / stand out

FP&A rewards the candidate who can *model and communicate*, so build proof of both. Create a portfolio project: take a listed company's public financials and build a driver-based three-statement model with a budget-vs-actual variance page and a scenario toggle (base/bull/bear), then summarise it in a one-page leadership deck — this single artifact demonstrates the exact skill FP&A hiring managers screen for. Master Excel modelling to a level beyond most peers, and learn the vocabulary of business drivers (unit economics, contribution margin, cost-to-serve). If you're a fresher, an MBA-Finance or CMA plus a strong modelling portfolio can get you in directly at the analyst rung. **The single biggest differentiator is the ability to explain a variance in business terms and recommend an action** — anyone can compute that spend was 8% over budget; the FP&A professional who says *why* and *what to do about it* is the one who becomes a Finance Business Partner.

Finance Controller / Controllership

Snapshot

The Financial Controller is the person who owns the accuracy of the numbers. Where an accountant records transactions and an FP&A analyst forecasts the future, the Controller is accountable for the *actuals* — the reported financial statements are right, close on time, compliant with Ind AS / Indian GAAP, and defensible in front of statutory auditors, the tax department and the board. It is the senior accounting leadership track: you sit above the R2R, AP/AR, payroll and general-ledger teams and report into the CFO or Head of Finance. In a startup or SME you may *be* the whole finance function; in a larger firm you run a team and a control framework. The typical ladder runs **Accounts Executive → Sr Executive / Assistant Manager (Finance) → Deputy Manager / Manager (Controllership) → Financial Controller → VP Finance / CFO**. Reaching Controller almost always means a CA (or many years of qualified-by-experience accounting), because the role is fundamentally about judgment on recognition, disclosure and controls, not just processing.

What you'll actually do

- Own the **end-to-end month, quarter and annual close** — drive the working-day (WD) close calendar, review journals (accruals, prepayments, provisions, intercompany, fixed assets, reclasses) and sign off the trial balance.
- Prepare and finalise **financial statements under Ind AS / Indian GAAP** — P&L, balance sheet, cash-flow statement, notes and disclosures.
- Design, operate and evidence **internal financial controls (IFC)** — approval matrices, segregation of duties, reconciliation sign-offs, and the documentation an auditor will test.
- Oversee **statutory, tax and internal audits** end to end — be the primary contact for the auditors, provide schedules, resolve queries, and clear observations.
- Own **direct and indirect tax compliance oversight** — GST returns, TDS, advance tax, income-tax filings — even where a specialist team executes them.
- Run **treasury and cash-flow forecasting** — visibility on liquidity, bank balances, working capital and funding needs.
- Review **balance-sheet reconciliations with commentary and ageing**, and chase down unexplained or stale items.

> Real posting (Plum): "Own the month, quarter and year-end close; prepare financial statements under Indian GAAP; establish and maintain internal financial controls; support statutory, tax and internal audits; and manage treasury and cash-flow forecasts."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: deep working knowledge of Ind AS / Indian GAAP and the Companies Act schedule III presentation; the full close-to-report cycle; internal financial controls design and testing; consolidation and intercompany elimination; GST / TDS / income-tax framework; treasury and cash-flow forecasting; audit management; advanced Excel (large-workbook modelling, reconciliations, pivot-driven schedules).

Soft skills: ownership and accountability (the buck stops with you on the numbers), the composure to face auditors and the board, the ability to explain a variance in plain business language, and the discipline to hit a fixed WD close every single month. People management and review discipline become central the moment you have a team.

Tools & software

- **ERP / accounting:** Zoho Books (SME/startup, as at Plum), Tally / TallyPrime (SME), SAP, Oracle NetSuite, Microsoft Dynamics (larger firms).
- **Excel** — non-negotiable; the Controller lives in reconciliations, schedules and close trackers.
- **Consolidation / reporting:** Fluence, OneStream or SAP BPC in bigger groups; often just Excel in mid-market.
- **Close & controls tooling:** BlackLine or FloQast for reconciliation and close management in mature finance teams.
- Tax/compliance portals: GSTN, TRACES, income-tax e-filing.

Qualifications & certifications

- **CA (ICAI) is the standard qualification** — most Controller and controllership-manager JDs say "CA-qualified", and Plum's asks for a qualified CA with 1–3 years. This is the single most valuable credential for the role in India.
- **CMA (ICMAI)** can substitute in cost-heavy manufacturing controllership, but CA dominates for statutory reporting.
- **ACCA / CPA (US)** matter if you're in a global-capability-centre (GCC) or a US/UK-parented entity doing IFRS/US GAAP.
- **MBA-Finance** helps for the business-partnering and leadership dimension but does *not* replace an accounting qualification here.
- CFA/FRM are largely irrelevant to controllership — they signal markets/risk, not reporting.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry to controllership	CA fresher–2 yrs	Executive / Sr Executive – Finance & Accounts, R2R Analyst
Mid	2–5 yrs	Assistant Manager / Deputy Manager – Controllership, Finance Manager
Senior	5–10 yrs	Financial Controller, Head of Controllership
Leadership	10+ yrs	VP Finance, CFO

A CA fresher does not walk straight into "Controller" — you earn it by owning close and audits for a few cycles first. In a small startup, though, a CA with 2–3 solid years can carry the Controller title because they *are* the function.

ATS keywords to mirror

Financial Controller, controllership, month-end close, quarter-end close, year-end close, Ind AS, Indian GAAP, financial statements, internal financial controls, IFC, statutory audit, tax audit, internal audit, GST, TDS, income tax, treasury, cash flow forecasting, balance sheet reconciliation, general ledger, consolidation, working capital, Schedule III, Companies Act, CA qualified, Zoho Books, Tally, SAP, variance analysis.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
CA fresher – 2 yrs (controllership exec)	9 – 14
2–4 yrs (AM / Deputy Manager)	14 – 22
5–8 yrs (Manager → Controller)	22 – 40

Approximate and varies materially by city, industry and whether it's an MNC/GCC vs an SME. Metro GCCs and funded startups pay at the top of these bands; SMEs and smaller cities well below.

Who's hiring

- **Startups and funded scale-ups** running lean finance — Plum (insurtech, Bangalore) is a good example; here the Controller is a broad, hands-on owner.
- **Global capability centres (GCCs)** of MNCs — controllership for group entities under IFRS/US GAAP.
- **Mid-market and manufacturing companies** needing statutory-reporting and IFC ownership.
- **Big 4 and consulting** — as a route in and out of controllership advisory (financial reporting, IFC/SOX).

How to break in / stand out

Get the CA first — for this role it is the ticket, not a nice-to-have. Then deliberately chase *close and audit* experience early: ask to own a balance-sheet area end to end, run reconciliations with commentary, and be the person who prepares the audit schedules. The candidate who impresses is the one who can say "I closed the books in 5 working days, prepared the Ind AS financials, and cleared the statutory audit with zero significant observations" — with specifics.

Build a portfolio proof point: a documented **close checklist / IFC control matrix** you designed, and a variance-commentary pack you produced. In interviews, be ready to talk through a genuine judgment call — a provision you sized, a revenue-recognition question under Ind AS 115, an audit observation you resolved.

The single biggest differentiator is **ownership under a deadline**: Controllers are trusted because they deliver an accurate close on a fixed day, month after month, and stand behind the numbers when auditors push. Demonstrate that reliability and the title follows.

Cost Accountant / Costing Analyst

Snapshot

The Cost Accountant is the person who answers "what does it actually cost us to make this?" — and then why the cost moved. Where a financial accountant reports what happened to the whole company and an FP&A analyst forecasts the P&L, the cost accountant works one level deeper and closer to the factory floor: unit economics, product and standard costing, inventory valuation, and the variances between what a product *should* cost and what it *did* cost. It is a manufacturing-heavy, CMA-flavoured discipline that sits in the finance/costing team and feeds pricing, margin and make-vs-buy decisions. The ladder typically runs **Costing Executive → Sr Costing Executive → Assistant Manager (Costing) → Manager (Cost & Management Accounting / Plant Finance) → Head of Costing / Plant Controller**. In India, the role also carries a statutory angle: certain companies must maintain cost records and undergo a **cost audit**, which keeps demand for qualified cost accountants steady.

What you'll actually do

- Build and maintain **standard costs and product cost sheets** — material, labour and overhead per unit — and update them as inputs and BOMs change.
- Run **variance analysis** — material price/usage, labour rate/efficiency, and overhead absorption variances — and explain them to plant and finance leadership.
- Perform **inventory valuation** — raw material, WIP and finished goods — and reconcile physical stock to books; investigate write-offs and slow-moving/obsolete stock.
- Do **margin and profitability analysis** by product, SKU, customer or plant, and flag loss-making lines.
- Support the **cost audit and cost records** compliance required under the Companies (Cost Records and Audit) Rules.
- Feed **pricing and make-vs-buy / cost-reduction** decisions with unit-economics data.
- Track **absorption of overheads** and reconcile cost accounts to the financial ledger at month-end.

> Real posting (manufacturing costing role): "Prepare and maintain standard costing and product cost sheets, perform variance analysis against actuals, value inventory (RM/WIP/FG), and support cost audit and margin reporting."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: costing methods (standard, marginal/variable, absorption, activity-based), variance analysis, inventory valuation (FIFO / weighted average) and the Ind AS 2 basics, BOM and overhead-absorption logic, cost-record and cost-audit requirements, strong Excel modelling, and the ability to read a manufacturing process and translate it into cost drivers.

Soft skills: comfort on the shop floor talking to production and stores teams; the ability to turn a variance into a plain-English story ("material price up 6% drove the miss, partly offset by better yield"); precision and a questioning mind about where costs really sit.

Cost accounting vs FP&A — the distinction

	Cost Accountant	FP&A Analyst
Focus	Product/unit cost, inventory, variances	Company P&L, budget vs actual
Altitude	Bottom-up, factory-level	Top-down, business-level
Core question	"What does this product cost and why?"	"Will we hit the plan and forecast?"
Home	Manufacturing, plant finance	Any industry, corporate finance
Cert edge	CMA (ICMAI)	MBA / CA / CMA

They overlap on variance analysis and Excel, but cost accounting is deeper on product economics and inventory; FP&A is broader and forward-looking on the whole P&L.

Tools & software

- **ERP costing modules:** SAP CO (Controlling) / SAP Material Ledger — the gold standard in Indian manufacturing; also Oracle and Microsoft Dynamics.
- **Excel** — the daily workhorse for cost sheets, variance bridges and inventory schedules.
- **Power BI / Tableau** for margin and cost dashboards.
- Plant/MES and inventory systems for consumption and production data.
- Tally in smaller manufacturers.

Qualifications & certifications

- **CMA (ICMAI) — Cost & Management Accountant — is the flagship credential** for this role in India and the one most directly aligned; it also carries the statutory right to sign cost audits.
- **CA (ICAI)** is respected and works well, especially for the reporting/reconciliation side.
- **B.Com / M.Com** is the common base degree; **MBA-Finance** helps for the management-accounting and business-partnering layer.
- **CIMA (UK)** / **CMA (US)** are useful in MNC/GCC environments doing global management accounting.
- CFA/FRM add little here — this is not a markets or risk role.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Fresher	0–2 yrs	Costing Executive, Cost Analyst, Trainee Cost Accountant
Mid	2–5 yrs	Sr Costing Executive, Assistant Manager – Costing / Cost & MA
Senior	5–8 yrs	Manager – Costing, Plant Finance Manager
Leadership	8+ yrs	Head of Costing, Cost Controller, Plant Controller

ATS keywords to mirror

Cost accountant, costing analyst, standard costing, product costing, cost sheet, variance analysis, material variance, labour variance, overhead absorption, inventory valuation, RM/WIP/FG, margin analysis, profitability analysis, cost audit, cost records, activity-based costing, marginal costing, absorption costing, BOM, SAP CO, material ledger, CMA, ICMAI, plant finance, cost reduction.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (CMA / B.Com)	4 – 8
2–4 yrs	8 – 14
5–8 yrs	14 – 24

Approximate and varies by city, industry and employer; large MNC manufacturers and auto/pharma plants pay at the higher end, smaller domestic manufacturers below. A qualified CMA typically starts meaningfully above a plain B.Com.

Who's hiring

- **Manufacturing** across the board — auto and auto-components, pharma, FMCG, chemicals, steel, cement, engineering.
- **Consumer and industrial goods** companies with large inventory and SKU counts.
- **GCCs / shared-service centres** running global management accounting and cost controlling.
- **Cost-audit and consulting firms** (practising Cost Accountants) for cost-records and cost-audit engagements.

How to break in / stand out

If you want this track, do the **CMA (ICMAI)** — it is the clearest signal and opens the statutory cost-audit door. Pair it with genuine curiosity about how things are made: the best cost accountants understand the process, not just the ledger. Get plant or factory exposure early, even a short stint, so you can speak to production and stores in their language.

Build a portfolio piece: take a product (real or realistic) and construct a **full cost sheet from BOM to per-unit cost**, then a **variance bridge** showing why actual differed from standard, with a one-page commentary. That single artefact demonstrates exactly the skill the JD wants and separates you from candidates who only know textbook formulae.

The biggest differentiator is being the person who **turns a cost variance into a decision** — not just reporting that material cost rose, but identifying the driver and recommending the pricing or sourcing action. Cost accountants who influence margin, rather than merely report it, are the ones who get promoted into plant finance and controllership.

Fund Accountant / Investment Operations

Snapshot

Fund accounting is where a huge share of Indian finance graduates actually enter the investment world — through the back and middle office of global asset managers, hedge funds, private-equity funds and administrators, run out of GCCs and third-party administrators in Bangalore, Mumbai, Pune, Hyderabad, Gurgaon and Chennai. A fund accountant doesn't pick stocks; they make sure the fund's books are right. The single most important number they produce is the **NAV (Net Asset Value)** — the per-unit price at which investors buy and sell — calculated on a strict daily, weekly or monthly cycle. Around that sit portfolio accounting, reconciliations, corporate actions and, for closed-end/PE funds, capital calls and distributions. It's high-volume, deadline-driven, process-heavy work with clear SLAs — and it's one of the most reliable ways for a B.Com / MBA-Finance fresher to get onto a finance career ladder inside a global name. The ladder runs **Analyst / Associate → Senior Analyst → Team Lead / Supervisor → Assistant Manager → Manager → AVP / VP (Fund Operations)**.

What you'll actually do

- Calculate and validate the **daily/periodic NAV** for one or more funds — strike the price, tie out to controls, and release within the SLA cut-off.
- Maintain **portfolio / investment accounting** — record trades, income (dividends, interest, coupons), accruals, and fee calculations (management and performance fees).
- Perform **reconciliations** — cash, positions and holdings between the fund's books, the custodian and the counterparties — and clear breaks.
- Process **corporate actions** — dividends, splits, mergers, rights, coupons — and reflect them correctly in positions and NAV.
- For PE/closed-end funds: process **capital calls and distributions**, maintain capital accounts and commitments/unfunded, and support **investor / LP reporting** (IRR, TVPI, DPI, NAV).
- Price securities and handle **pricing/valuation exceptions**, escalating stale or hard-to-value positions.
- Meet **SLAs and audit/regulatory deadlines**, and support fund audits with schedules and reconciliations.

> Real posting (investment-operations style): "Calculate daily NAV, book trades and income, reconcile cash and positions against the custodian, process corporate actions and resolve breaks within agreed SLAs."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: NAV computation and the components of a fund's balance sheet, trade lifecycle and settlement, reconciliations and break resolution, corporate-action processing, security types (equity, fixed income, derivatives) and how each is priced/accrued, strong Excel, and comfort reading a custodian/administrator statement.

Soft skills: precision under a hard cut-off (a wrong NAV is a real problem), process discipline, break-chasing tenacity, clear escalation, and the stamina for high volumes. Many roles run **shifts aligned to US/EU**

markets — night or evening shifts are common, so flexibility matters.

Tools & software

- **Fund-accounting platforms:** SS&C Geneva, SimCorp Dimension, Multifonds, Advent APX, BNY's / State Street's proprietary systems, InvestOne.
- **Excel** — universal for reconciliations, checks and NAV support.
- **Bloomberg / Refinitiv** for pricing and security reference data.
- Custodian and administrator portals; SWIFT/settlement systems in ops-heavy roles.

Qualifications & certifications

- **B.Com / M.Com / BBA / MBA-Finance** is the standard entry degree — this is one of the most graduate-accessible finance tracks.
- **NISM series** (e.g. Series V-A Mutual Fund Distributors, or the relevant operations modules) are inexpensive, India-recognised signals that you understand the product.
- **CFA (Level 1+)** genuinely helps for progression, valuation understanding and moving toward middle/front office over time.
- **IMC (Investment Management Certificate, UK)** and fund-ops certifications are valued in GCCs.
- **CA / CMA** are not required and can even be "overqualified" for pure fund accounting, though they help you rise into controllership over the fund.
- FRM helps if you move toward risk/valuation.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Fresher	0–2 yrs	Fund Accountant, Investment Operations Analyst, NAV Analyst, Associate
Mid	2–5 yrs	Senior Fund Accountant, Team Lead, Senior Associate
Senior	5–8 yrs	Assistant Manager / Manager – Fund Operations
Leadership	8+ yrs	AVP / VP – Fund Accounting / Investment Operations

ATS keywords to mirror

Fund accounting, NAV calculation, net asset value, portfolio accounting, investment operations, reconciliation, cash reconciliation, position reconciliation, corporate actions, capital calls, distributions, LP reporting, IRR, TVPI, DPI, trade settlement, custodian, pricing, valuation, SLA, Geneva, SimCorp, Multifonds, Advent, Bloomberg, fixed income, derivatives, mutual fund, private equity, hedge fund.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher	4 – 7
2–4 yrs	7 – 13
5–8 yrs	13 – 24

Approximate and varies by employer, shift and city. Large global administrators and asset-manager GCCs pay competitively; night-shift and complex-product (derivatives, PE) roles often carry a premium. Progression is steady but volume-driven — moving up usually means owning more complex funds or a team.

Who's hiring

The big employers are the fund administrators and asset-manager GCCs, hiring at scale in India: - **Citco, Northern Trust, State Street, SS&C, BNY (Mellon)** — the marquee names in fund admin / investment operations. - **JPMorgan, HSBC, Franklin Templeton, BlackRock (Aladdin ops), Fidelity, Invesco** — asset-manager captive centres. - **Apex, Standard Chartered, Deutsche Bank** and other custodian/administrator operations.

How to break in / stand out

This is one of the most *learnable* finance entries — you don't need a top-tier pedigree, you need accuracy, product knowledge and reliability. Get the fundamentals cold: be able to explain, in an interview, exactly **how NAV is calculated** and what moves it, what a reconciliation break is, and how a corporate action flows through positions. That alone puts you ahead of most freshers who apply blind.

Signal product knowledge cheaply: clear an **NISM module or CFA Level 1**, and learn to read a fund fact sheet. Build a small portfolio piece — a mock **NAV computation in Excel** for a sample portfolio (positions, prices, accruals, fees → per-unit NAV), plus a reconciliation showing you can spot and clear a break. Show it.

The single biggest differentiator is **precision under a deadline plus curiosity to move up**: many people process NAVs; the ones who get promoted understand *why* the number is what it is, catch errors before the cut-off, and treat fund accounting as the on-ramp to valuation, middle office or fund controllership rather than a dead end. Accept the night shifts early — they're where the best global-fund experience lives.

Core-Finance Skills, Tools & Certification Matrix

This closing chapter pulls the whole book together into decision tools. The roles you've read about — accounting, tax, audit/controllership, R2R, payroll, FP&A, cost accounting, fund accounting and the analyst tracks — share a common toolkit but demand it in different proportions. Use the matrices below to see where your current skills already qualify you, and where a single new skill or certification unlocks a role.

Role × skill matrix

How heavily each core-finance role leans on each skill. **Core** = you must have it. **Useful** = expected/plus. **Rare** = seldom needed for this role.

Role	Tally	Excel	SQL	Power BI	GST/TDS	Ind AS	SAP	Month-end	Recon
Accountant / Accounts Exec	Core	Core	Rare	Rare	Core	Useful	Useful	Core	Core
Tax Analyst	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Useful	Useful	Useful	Useful
Audit / Controllership	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core	Useful	Core	Core
R2R / GL Accountant	Rare	Core	Useful	Useful	Useful	Useful	Core	Core	Core
Payroll	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core
Financial Analyst (asset data)	Rare	Core	Useful	Core	Rare	Rare	Useful	Useful	Core
FP&A Analyst	Rare	Core	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core	Useful
Financial Controller	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core	Core	Core	Core
Cost Accountant	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Useful	Useful	Core	Core	Core
Fund Accountant	Rare	Core	Useful	Useful	Rare	Useful	Useful	Core	Core

Read the columns, not just the rows. **Excel, month-end and reconciliation are "Core" almost everywhere** — they are the non-negotiable spine of core finance. **Tally is Core only at the SME accountant end; SAP is Core at the R2R/FP&A/controllership/costing end** — the two rarely overlap, which is why SME and GCC finance feel like different worlds. **SQL and Power BI are the rising differentiators** — still "Useful" not "Core" for most roles, which is exactly why learning them now moves you ahead of the field.

Certification decoder — which cert for which role

Cert	Best for	Skip if
CA (ICAI)	Controllership, audit, tax, statutory reporting — the gold standard for accounting leadership	You're aiming at markets/research/risk (CFA/FRM fit better)
CMA (ICMAI)	Cost accounting, plant finance, management accounting, cost audit (statutory)	You want statutory financial-reporting sign-off (that's CA)
CS (ICSI)	Company secretarial, corporate/secretarial compliance, governance	Your target is core numbers/reporting, not compliance/law
MBA-Finance	FP&A, business partnering, IB/ER/PE analyst tracks, general management path	You need statutory sign-off or deep costing (add CA/CMA)
ACCA	GCC / MNC roles under IFRS, global reporting, controllership in captives	You're purely India-statutory focused (CA is more recognised locally)
CPA (US)	US-GAAP entities, US-parented GCCs, controllership in American MNCs	No US/IFRS exposure in your target roles
NISM series	Fund accounting, investment operations, broking, wealth/markets-facing roles	You're in pure accounting/tax/controllership
CFA	Equity research, IB, PE, fund management, valuation, risk progression	You're on the accounting/compliance track
FRM	Credit/market/model risk, risk analytics	You're not touching risk
ACAMS	KYC/AML and financial-crime compliance	Not in a compliance/AML role
FMVA	A fast, practical modelling signal for FP&A/analyst freshers with no MBA	You already have CA/MBA + real modelling experience

One-line rule of thumb: *CA for the numbers being right, CMA for what things cost, MBA for the story and the room, CFA/FRM for markets and risk, NISM/ACAMS/FMVA for cheap, targeted signals.* Don't stack certs randomly — pick the one that matches the row you want in the matrix above.

Universal ATS keyword bank (core finance)

Mirror the terms that match *your* target role from its chapter, but these recur across almost every core-finance JD and belong on most resumes:

Process & reporting: month-end close, quarter-end close, year-end close, general ledger, journal entries, accruals, prepayments, provisions, financial statements, balance sheet reconciliation, variance analysis, management reporting, financial reporting.

Compliance & tax: GST, TDS, income tax, statutory compliance, statutory audit, tax audit, internal audit, internal financial controls, Ind AS, Indian GAAP, IFRS.

Tools: Tally / TallyPrime, SAP, Oracle, Zoho Books, Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables, INDEX-MATCH, SUMIFS), Power BI, Tableau, SQL, Anaplan, Hyperion.

Transactional: accounts payable, accounts receivable, bank reconciliation, 3-way reconciliation, intercompany reconciliation, fixed assets, depreciation, payroll processing.

Analytical: budgeting, forecasting, financial modelling, KPI reporting, cash-flow forecasting, cost analysis, margin analysis.

Use the *exact* casing and phrasing from the posting where you can (e.g. "R2R" and "record to report", "AP/AR" and "accounts payable/receivable") — ATS filters often match literally.

90-day "become hireable" action list

A concrete plan for a commerce / MBA-Finance candidate to go from "studying finance" to "shortlist-worthy" for a core-finance role.

Days 1–30 — Build the spine. - Get genuinely strong in **Excel**: lookups, PivotTables, SUMIFS/INDEX-MATCH, a clean 3-statement or cost model. This single skill is "Core" in every row above. - Learn one **accounting/ERP tool** end to end — **Tally** if you're targeting SME/accounting roles, **SAP FICO basics** if you're targeting GCC/R2R/controllership. - Nail the fundamentals of **GST, TDS and the month-end close cycle** — be able to explain them out loud.

Days 31–60 — Add a differentiator + a credential. - Learn the basics of **SQL and Power BI** — still "Useful" not universal, which is precisely why they lift you above other freshers. - Start (or clear the first level of) the **one certification** that matches your target row: CA/CMA if you're in for the long accounting haul, NISM/FMVA/CFA-L1 for fast, cheap signals toward analyst/fund roles. - Rewrite your resume to **mirror the ATS keywords** from your two target chapters.

Days 61–90 — Prove it with a portfolio. - Build **one real artefact** for your target role: a month-end close checklist + reconciliation pack (accounting/controllership); a product cost sheet + variance bridge (costing); a NAV computation + break-resolution sheet (fund accounting); a budget-vs-actual variance model (FP&A). - Do a **mock of the role's core deliverable** end to end and be ready to walk an interviewer through it. - Apply in a **focused batch** to the real employer types named in each chapter — SMEs for accounting, GCCs (Genpact, Accenture, Citi, State Street, Northern Trust, SS&C) for R2R/FP&A/fund ops — and tailor each resume to that specific posting.

The honest truth this book keeps returning to: core-finance roles reward **reliability and specificity** over prestige. The candidate who can *show* one clean close, one solid variance bridge, one correct NAV — and speak the exact language of the JD — beats the candidate with a longer degree list and nothing to demonstrate. Pick your row, build the spine, add the one cert that fits, and prove it with one artefact. That's the whole game.